



Combat Mindset

Framework Proposal

Remain effective. Act decisively.
Harder to kill.

Reference	ACS 2026
Date	August 2026
Originator	Army Command School
Version	Draft v1.0

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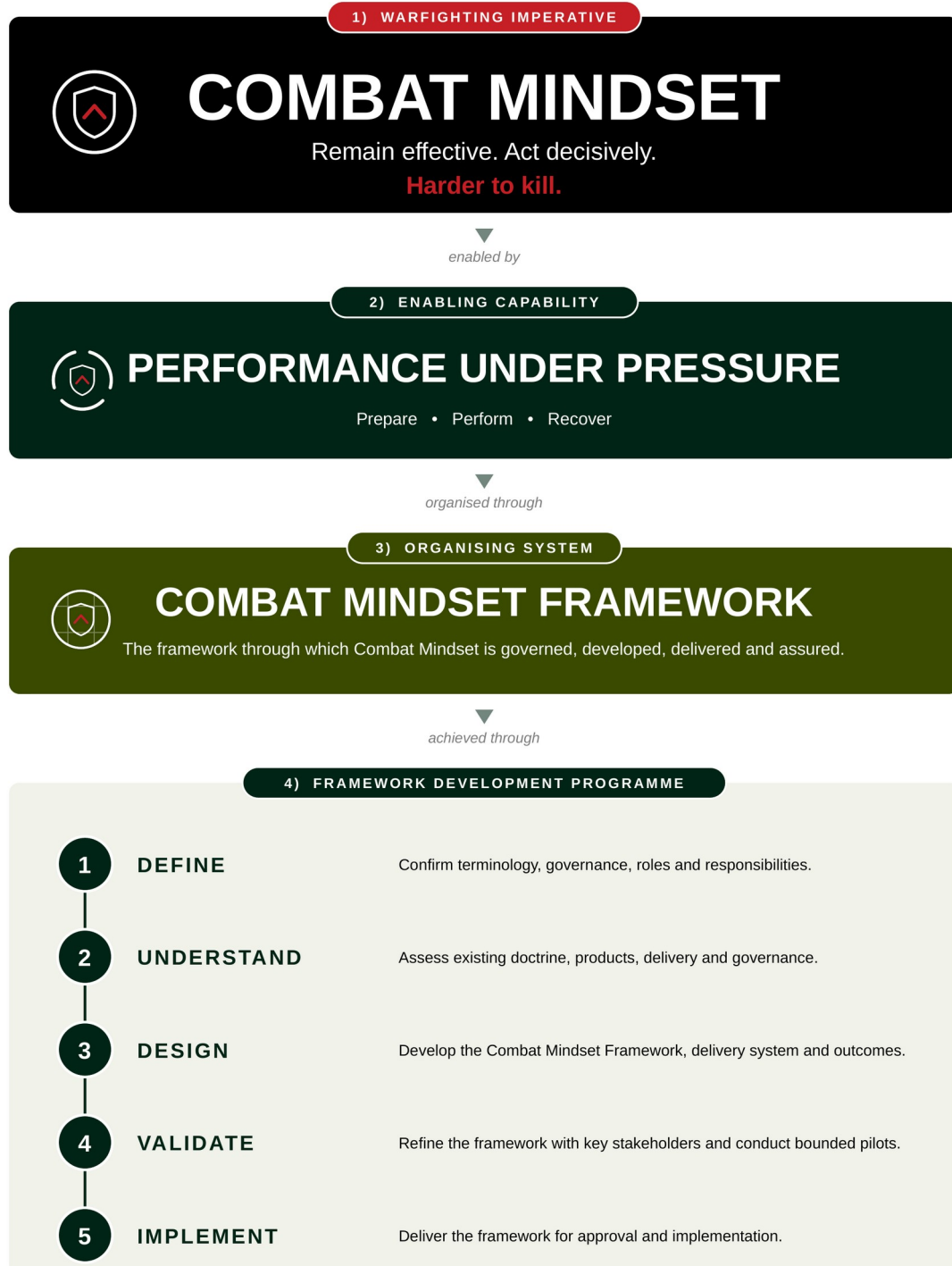
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The Model on a Page



COMBAT MINDSET FRAMEWORK PROPOSAL

Army Command School



Purpose

This paper responds to COMDT ACS direction of 16 July 2026 for NZ Army Leadership Centre (NZALC), in conjunction with the Human Performance Cell (HPC), to develop a strategy to close the Combat Mindset policy and doctrine gap. It proposes a problem statement, initial working definitions and their relationship, the Combat Mindset Framework as the organising system, and a programme of work, for decision.

The programme of work is phased: Phase 1 defines terminology, governance, roles and responsibilities; Phase 2 assesses existing doctrine, products, delivery and governance; Phase 3 designs the framework, its delivery system and outcomes; Phase 4 validates the framework with key stakeholders and conducts bounded pilots; and Phase 5 delivers the framework for approval and implementation.

Final recommendations and an implementation back brief will return to COMDT ACS in November 2026.

1. The problem

Considerable work on Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure already exists across Army. What Army does not yet have is a coherent doctrine, governance and assurance model for Combat Mindset. The COMDT ACS guidance reaches the same diagnosis:

Substantial relevant capability already exists across ACS, NZALC, the Human Performance Cell, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and units. The challenge is not primarily a lack of content. It is a lack of visibility, integration, common terminology, strategic ownership and assurance across that existing capability.

The underlying operational problem remains:

Under operational pressure, trained individuals and teams do not always retain access to their full capability.

The doctrinal requirement is therefore to define the human-performance capability Army requires, consolidate the substantial body of work that already exists beneath it, and describe its combat-specific expression. Sufficient evidence and existing capability are available to commence this programme of work in order to achieve that end state.

2. Terminology and definitions: decision sought

One structural decision must be made before the framework can be drafted: the relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure. Two options are offered.

Option 1: Combat Mindset as the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure (recommended)

Combat Mindset is the individual and collective readiness and disposition Army seeks under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat. It is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure.

Performance Under Pressure is the enabling human-performance capability: the trainable individual and collective capacity to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from pressure. It is applicable across combat, command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity. Combat Mindset places that broader capability within its specifically warfighting context and connects it to Army's mission, identity, values and operational purpose.

The Combat Mindset Framework is the organising system through which Army will govern, develop, deliver and assure this effect across provisional capability pillars, developmental outcomes, training products and governance arrangements.

The following formal definitions are proposed as the drafting baseline.

Combat Mindset. *The individual and collective readiness and disposition to remain effective and act decisively and ethically under the threat, adversity and uncertainty of combat in order to achieve the mission. It is the combat-specific expression of Performance Under Pressure.*

Performance Under Pressure. *The trainable individual and collective human-performance capability to prepare for, maintain effective performance through, adapt within and recover from conditions that create significant physiological, cognitive, emotional or social interference.*

Combat Mindset Framework. *The framework through which Combat Mindset is governed, developed, delivered and assured.*

A product, method or activity is combat-specific where it develops or applies Performance Under Pressure under conditions characteristic of combat: an opposed or threat-bearing context, consequence for mission and life, and ethical load. Products lacking these conditions contribute to the enabling capability rather than its combat-specific expression.

Performance Under Pressure describes the trainable human-performance capability. Combat Mindset describes the specifically combat-oriented expression of that capability.

- Gives each term one clear purpose: Combat Mindset is the combat-specific expression; Performance Under Pressure is the enabling capability; the Combat Mindset Framework is the organising system.
- Keeps Performance Under Pressure applicable wherever significant pressure exists without an enemy; command, crisis response, training, garrison leadership and high-risk technical activity.
- Guards against Combat Mindset being misread as aggression, motivation or resilience alone.

Option 2: Combat Mindset as the complete umbrella capability

Combat Mindset is treated as the complete capability itself, integrating leadership, human performance, resilience, mental skills and performance cognition, with performance under pressure expressed within it.

- Maximises simplicity: one term serves as outcome, capability and framework alike.
- Matches common soldier usage, in which Combat Mindset already serves as the umbrella term, and avoids a two-term hierarchy that requires sustained explanation.
- Conflates the combat-specific outcome with the broader human-performance capability, reducing applicability outside combat.
- Makes it difficult to distinguish doctrine, capability, framework and product.
- Increases the risk that Combat Mindset is interpreted as motivation or aggression alone.

Both options deliver the end state described in the COMDT ACS guidance. NZALC and HPC jointly recommend Option 1, and will implement whichever option COMDT ACS selects.

3. What already exists

Allied armies have fielded comparable integrated human-performance programmes, including US Army Holistic Health and Fitness [verify], UK Op SMART [verify] and ADF BattleSMART [verify]. The structure proposed in this paper (a single organising framework beneath which existing products are nested and assured) is consistent with that direction.

A full assessment of existing capability and products will be completed during Phase 2. The products described below contribute to the development of Performance Under Pressure and, where applied in a warfighting context, to Combat Mindset. They do not constitute the doctrinal definitions or the complete framework in isolation. Initial holdings include the following.

NZALC Performance Under Pressure package

NZALC delivers a leadership-development approach incorporating Performance = Potential – Interference, Red Head–Blue Head, Prepare–Perform–Recover, mental-skills techniques, psychometrics, experiential activity, feedback and Leadership Development Plans. This material is embedded across Lead Self, Lead Teams, Lead Leaders and Lead Systems.

Human Performance Cell Cognitive Conditioning programme (COGCON)

COGCON is a developmental cognitive-conditioning product targeting selected aspects of performance cognition under physical and cognitive load, including arousal regulation, attention, cognitive control and working memory. Feasibility trials in military training have demonstrated acceptability and promising training trends. Its causal effectiveness, operational transfer, readiness validity, scalability and enduring delivery model have not yet been established. Its status and appropriate future role will be confirmed through the Phase 2 assessment.

NZDF Psychology, ILD and other stakeholders

These organisations hold additional professional expertise, learning products, delivery capability and assurance functions that will be confirmed during the Phase 2 assessment.

Initial review indicates considerable conceptual alignment across existing products. The Combat Mindset Framework will establish a common doctrinal language beneath which individual products and methods can be appropriately nested. It will not require all products to use identical internal methodologies, provided they align to the endorsed framework, outcomes and assurance requirements.

4. Proposed programme of work

The programme will be conducted within existing ACS, NZALC and HPC baselines; no new resource is sought before the November 2026 report. Proposed phase leads are shown against each phase and are subject to confirmation.

Phase 1: Define and govern (on endorsement of this paper; target mid-August 2026) (ACS) [proposed – confirm]

Confirm terminology, governance, roles and responsibilities: endorse the problem statement, select the terminology option at paragraph 2, confirm interim sponsorship and capability-integration arrangements, and draft for staffing the endorsed definitions of Combat Mindset, Performance Under Pressure and the Combat Mindset Framework, together with the agreed relationship between the three.

Phase 2: Understand (August–September 2026) (NZALC lead, HPC support) [proposed – confirm]

Assess existing doctrine, content, products, courses, instructor capability, delivery activity, evidence, ownership and assurance arrangements across ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, training establishments and selected units. The assessment will distinguish:

- doctrinal and policy holdings;
- capability outcomes;
- training products and methods;
- delivery organisations;
- technical and professional authorities;
- evidence maturity;
- scalability and resource requirements; and
- gaps, duplication and integration opportunities.

The assessment will identify which products contribute to the broader Performance Under Pressure capability and which support its combat-specific expression, using the combat-specificity test at paragraph 2. COGCON will be assessed as one developmental product within this assessment, with particular attention to its product boundary, evidence base (including its completed feasibility trials in live military training), ownership, workforce requirements and scalability.

Phase 3: Design (September–October 2026) (NZALC/HPC joint) [proposed – confirm]

Develop the Combat Mindset Framework, delivery system and outcomes: the organising system through which Army will govern, develop, deliver and assure Performance Under Pressure and its combat-specific expression. The framework will include the endorsed definitions and desired operational effect; the provisional capability pillars, refined through the assessment; developmental outcomes from Lead Self through Lead Systems; the relationship between doctrine, framework, products and delivery; common assurance principles; and the criteria by which existing and future products may be recognised as contributing to the framework.

The provisional working pillars are: leadership under pressure; self-regulation and mental skills; performance cognition; resilience, adaptation and recovery; physical readiness and performance; professional identity, values and will to act; and team and collective performance. These are provisional working pillars, subject to validation through the Phase 2 assessment and Phase 4 validation. Each describes an enduring capability Army seeks to build. Training products and methods (including progressive exposure to pressure, scenario and experiential training, field and mission-relevant rehearsal, and physical and cognitive conditioning) are how Army builds them.

Existing products, including the NZALC Performance Under Pressure package and COGCON, will be mapped beneath the relevant provisional capability pillars rather than treated as the framework itself.

Phase 4: Validate (October 2026) (ACS convenes) [proposed – confirm]

Refine the framework with key stakeholders and conduct bounded pilots: convene ACS, NZALC, HPC, NZDF Psychology, ILD, selected training providers and units to refine the framework, product architecture, governance model, implementation priorities, definition clarity and doctrinal coherence.

Phase 5: Implement (November 2026) (ACS) [proposed – confirm]

Deliver the framework for approval and implementation: present the endorsed definitions and the confirmed relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure; Framework v1.0 and its agreed architecture; the validated capability and product architecture; the proposed governance and assurance model; an assessment of existing product maturity, evidence and scalability; and a prioritised implementation plan.

Framework development principles

Framework development will be guided by the following principles:

- Consolidate and align existing capability before creating new content.
- Use clear, common and Army-relevant language.
- Distinguish capability outcomes from training products and methods.
- Remain evidence-informed and proportionate to the maturity of each product.
- Avoid capture by any single organisation, discipline or product.
- Use existing training and leadership systems wherever practicable.
- Develop from Lead Self through Lead Systems.

- Validate operational relevance with training establishments and units.
- Design governance and assurance into the framework from the outset.

5. Governance

The following arrangements are proposed for confirmation at Phase 1. Technical and professional authority is distributed by domain; no single organisation owns the evidence base for the entire capability.

- Army Sponsor: strategic sponsor for Combat Mindset, the enabling Performance Under Pressure capability and the Combat Mindset Framework; to be confirmed at Phase 1, with candidate options identified by ACS.
- Interim capability integrator: COMDT ACS, coordinating definition, framework development, stakeholder engagement and recommendations to the Army Sponsor.
- Framework development and capability-integration lead: ACS, coordinating framework architecture, developmental progression, stakeholder integration, product recognition criteria and implementation planning, leveraging NZALC and wider ACS expertise, intellectual property and programmes.
- COGCON product steward and performance-cognition adviser: Human Performance Cell, responsible for the integrity and further development of the COGCON method and for specialist advice on cognitive conditioning and proportionate measurement, within available capacity.
- Domain advisers and authorities: NZDF Psychology, ILD, physical-performance specialists, doctrine staff and other relevant organisations, providing technical or professional advice within their respective domains.
- Delivery agencies: training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces approved to deliver recognised products.
- Assurance: a layered assurance model covering doctrine, evidence, professional content, learning design, delivery quality and operational relevance, with sufficient independence from individual product owners and delivery organisations.

6. Recommendations

It is recommended that COMDT ACS:

1. **Endorse** the problem statement at paragraph 1 and the recommended relationship between Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure at paragraph 2.
2. **Endorse** the proposed definitions of Combat Mindset, Performance Under Pressure and the Combat Mindset Framework as the baseline for wider staffing and refinement.
3. **Approve** development of the Combat Mindset Framework through the proposed capability and product assessment, framework design and validation activity, noting that the provisional capability pillars and the contribution, maturity, evidence,

ownership and appropriate nesting of existing products (including the NZALC Performance Under Pressure package, COGCON and NZDF Psychology products) will be validated through this process.

4. **Confirm** the interim governance arrangements at paragraph 5, including COMDT ACS as interim capability integrator pending confirmation of the Army Sponsor, ACS as framework development and capability-integration lead, and technical and professional authority distributed by domain.
5. **Seek** confirmation of the Army Sponsor by 31 August 2026, with candidate options identified by ACS.
6. **Decide** the status of Harder to Kill within the proposed Combat Mindset tagline (Remain effective. Act decisively. Harder to kill.), endorsing, deferring or rejecting its inclusion.
7. **Direct** a report back in November 2026 containing the endorsed definitions; Framework v1.0; the validated capability and product architecture; proposed governance and assurance arrangements; an assessment of existing product maturity, evidence and scalability; and a prioritised implementation plan.

Foundation documents

This paper draws on the following documents:

- COMDT ACS Combat Mindset guidance, 16 July 2026.
- Performance Under Pressure and Combat Mindset in the New Zealand Army (Draft Capability Note), NZALC, July 2026.
- Human Performance Cell Performance Cognition paper (COGCON).

Relevant NZDF Psychology, ILD and doctrinal holdings will be confirmed and referenced through the Phase 2 assessment.

Annex A: Interim governance and division of functions

The following division of functions is proposed for confirmation at Phase 1 and refinement through the Phase 2 assessment and Phase 4 validation.

Function	Lead	Output
Define and govern	Army Sponsor / ACS	Endorsed doctrine, definitions, policy direction and capability outcomes
Integrate capability and develop the framework	ACS	Framework architecture, product recognition criteria, stakeholder coordination and implementation priorities
Develop products	Relevant product owner	Product design, protocols, instructor materials and updates
Provide domain advice	Relevant technical or professional adviser	Specialist advice within leadership, psychology, cognition, learning design, physical performance and other domains
Deliver	Approved training establishments, units and existing instructor workforces	Routine delivery of recognised products
Measure training performance	Delivery organisation, using approved methods	Proportionate training feedback and product-level performance data
Evaluate product effectiveness	Product owner, with independent evaluation or research support	Evidence of feasibility, effectiveness, transfer and scalability
Assure	Layered governance and domain authorities	Doctrine, evidence, professional, learning, delivery and operational assurance
Review and recover	Relevant leadership and training systems	Reflection, feedback, recovery and developmental planning